3

THE CASTE GAME

How the BJP Became the Most Socially Representative Party in UP (Barring Muslims)

The BJP has long been considered an upper-caste-dominated party by scholars who study it. This perception might have been true in its early years but new caste data that I have put together for this book shows that research and scholarship on the party have lagged behind the party's reality. In June 2020, Prime Minister Narendra Modi pointed out in a video address to his party workers that the BJP was represented by 113 OBC, 43 ST and 53 SC MPs in the Lok Sabha.[1] In other words, a full 37.2 per cent of BJP Lok Sabha MPs were OBC, 14.1 per cent ST and 17.4 per cent SC. This meant that a whopping 68.9 per cent (209) of all its 303 Lok Sabha MPs elected in 2019 were non-upper castes and from castes that were traditionally considered lower down in the caste hierarchy. This is strikingly on par with the widely accepted national share of the population of these castes: 69.2 per cent. The charge of upper caste domination is difficult to make with such electoral representation. Furthermore, if you leave out seats reserved by law for SCs or STs alone, non-upper castes still accounted for almost 60 per cent of BJP MPs elected from general constituencies. Within this, as many as 50 per cent (113) of the BJP's Lok Sabha MPs elected from general constituencies were OBCs.[2]